

had put on her card in just one day, but what else could she have done? She couldn't sit on crates. She took a day off work to wait for the delivery of her things, and since that all occurred in the morning, spent the afternoon charging her purchases for art and colored pillows and the like to splash her townhouse with her own sense of style.

She had been used to having her necessities paid for and actually made a conscious decision not to lower her standard of living. *What for?* she reasoned. She had a good job, was only responsible for herself, and liked nice things. She didn't bother renting DVDs; instead she bought her favorites. She dressed well for work, purposely dressing in suits, since she was a professional in the business office of the dental practice, and didn't need to wear scrubs as the hygienists and assistants did. She opened charge accounts in several classy department stores. She enjoyed vacations with friends or some of her many cousins, financing it all with plastic. Penny didn't concern herself with the total amount of debt she was accumulating, since she had no trouble making the minimum payments. She added another major credit card to her wallet, and her original two increased her spending limit.

Penny often shifted balances around to other cards to take advantage of better offers and interest rates, and thereby prided herself on handling her money well. By the time she was thirty, Penny had accumulated \$20,000 in consumer debt.

Around that time, she decided to move on from the dental practice and found a job with a large insurance company in the city. Her commute was longer, but her car was still running well and was nearly paid for. She was startled, however, when, during her initial interview, the rep from human resources told her that employees were encouraged to keep their personal finances in order because major credit problems could hinder their performance. Penny decided to rein in her spending and within two years was able to cut her debt in half.

But then her car gave out, and she decided to again finance a new one rather than saving for a used one, telling herself there was no